HEROES OF NORMANDIE

The Devil Pig News

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THE VERCORS MAQUIS

BE ENTICED BY THE MOUNTAINS!!!

The Vercors mountain range, situated Southwest of Grenoble, had been a sought-after destination long before the German offensive of July 1944. Already at the end of 1939, refugees appeared in the area. Amongst them, several well-off foreign families on the run from Nazism but also lots of youngsters, Parisien or Southern French kids straight out of their primary or secondary school. This situation lasted until the start of 1942 when several groups of guerilla fighters joined up with the Lyon resistance organisation. Their first actions consisted primarily of receiving STO (forced labor) dodgers and offering them hospitality. Nothing beats fresh mountain air to heal and strengthen people.

"Mountainmen must keep scaling the mountains."

This coded message sent by the BBC on the 25th of February 1943 caused the movement to pick up the pace as they carried on with what they had been doing since 1942: create makeshift landing strips and stock up on weapons and ammunition. Moreover, by denying all access to unwelcome outsiders, they turned the Vercors plateau into a sanctuary. Around this time, as these resistants were then considered part of the Secret Army, they could benefit from funds allocated by Jean Moulin. As this allowed the organization to grow stronger, their ranks counted about 400 partisans ready and able to fight by the end of 1943. From November '43 parachute drops provided them with the material to mount guerilla and sabotage actions against the Germans who had replaced the Italian occupation forces in September.



In the beginning of 1944, German forces aided by Vichy Régime militants launched a series of missions against the Vercors. The resistants did all they could to avoid being drawn into a full scale battle as that would do them more bad than good. The inhabitants of the region who might support the Resistance paid a heavy toll as they were repressed, abused and deported. On the first of June 1944, London sent the, perhaps oddly humoristic, encoded message "There is water in the gas". This was to warn the French about the imminent Operation Overlord and to keep them on their toes because they needed to distract and annoy the Germans then more than ever. The command of the Vercors (united FFI since February 1944) is entrusted to Lieutenant colonel Huet and his chief of staff Captain Pierre Tannant. At that time, the Vercors could muster about 4000 men supported by reinforcements from adjoining regions.

"The Alpine mountain goat jumps"... does it?

To no avail rather... Since "Overlord" was well underway in Normandie and more landings were being projected in the South of France, any potential offensive actions carried out by the Vercors Resistance were no longer a priority at all for the Allies. Lack of proper communication between London and Vercors on this matter seriously affected the planned operation "Montagnards" (Mountainmen) which even triggered a conflict of influence between several covert offices of Free France. Anyway, halfway through 1944, since the area had been proclaimed as "République Libre du Vercors" (Free Republic of Vercors), the people on the plateau considered it a liberated area and acted accordingly. Although massive amounts of arms and material were still being airdropped, alas, the promised airborne reinforcements did not appear. The fact that the resistants thus remained an isolated armed band was to the Germans' advantage as they launched their final offensive to deal with these staunch belligerents once and for all.

The 157th Reserve Division was to be renamed 157th Mountain Division in September 1944. They had been busy fighting resistance and sabotage groups since April of the same year, successfully securing the Glières plateau in the process. In early July it fell on them to conduct Operation Bettina, the attack on the Vercors, for which 8000 men were mobilized. This force included Paratroops, Security units, SS Feldgendarme and Police battalions. As a bitter matter of fact these Germans were assisted by about 500... French militants. The enterprise was to be similar to the efforts made against Tito's partisans in Yugoslavia. On July 13 and 14, the Luftwaffe unleashed hell by pounding the plateau with a massive bombardment. The ground assault commenced on the 21st of July, followed by a glider attack on the 23rd. The stalwart French were unable to oppose the onslaught for long because they were lacking heavy equipment even though the Allies had maintained the logistical parachute drops. As atrocities and warcrimes were plentiful, it didn't take long before the defenders' fate was sealed ... When at long last, in August 1944, airborne troops finally parachuted in during Operation Dragoon, their help came too late for the Vercors.

There's still quite a lot of controversy surrounding the Vercors maquis' destiny. Some tardy decisions of the Free French command and the Allies' role are quite obscure. They can provoke discussions in which words like crime and cowardice might not be shunned at all. In spite of its strategic significance being open for debate as well, there is no denying the Vercors is worthy of a venerable place in the history of French national Resistance during the second World War.

Laurent

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Pierre Tanant

Medals of Honor:
Croix de Guerre 1939-1945 (Cross of War),
Médaille militaire (Military medal),
Médaille de la résistance (Resistance medal).

When plowing through the after-action reports of operations or mission orders from the French army pertaining to episodes which happened in the first half of the 20th century or even a bit later, one can experience the joy of stumbling upon some delightfully outdated expressions. You may come across "sans esprit de recul" (without any spirit of retreat), "avec un bel allant" (with a beautiful going = energy, pace), or the little gem "Boches pris au poste" (Krauts offed at their post) found in a citation written by general Leclerc for one of my relatives in days long before there was any talk of political correctness. Words sometimes take on extra or different meanings and have a variable degree of impact related to the time and context in which they are used.

Pierre Tanant, chief of staff and captain at the time of the Vercors battles, descended from one of those families where "for the homeland" literally meant "gained by the blood that was spilled for it, yours, your father's, his father's and of any other fathers in your ancestry." Back then the expression still carried some seriously solemn gravity, unlike in later days where it might be treated as negligible in some postmodern talk-show...

Pierre Tanant was born in 1909 in Lorraine. His father was a general, ingrained with the sense of importance given to words like honor, homeland and duty. After Saint Cyr military academy, Tanant is assigned to the 153rd regiment of Tirailleurs algériens based in Morocco. In 1938 he has the rank of captain in the 13th Bataillon de Chasseurs Alpins (BCA). He takes part in the campaign in Norway and battles at the Somme in 1940 before being transferred to the armistice army as part of the 6th BCA.

In November '42, as the French free zone was invaded by the Germans, Tanant aided in concealing arms and material. He also took a very active part in setting up a core of fighting units in the Vercors maquis as the chief of staff under lieutenant colonel Huet's orders. During the second semester of 1944 these very combatants were fighting the assaulting enemy on the Vercors plateau. It is a most remarkable feat in the history of the French Resistance.



After World War II, Tanant was part of the occupation forces in Austria. Next he was off to serve in the Algerian War. With the rank of colonel he left the army because of a personal conflict between political obedience and a sense of duty towards the local people. He formulated things as such: "The word that, way too often, is but a word for the politician, assumes the form of a terrible fact for the soldier: words spoken lightly and falsely by one will be written in the dust with the blood of another."

For a long time Pierre Tanant was committed to the remembrance of the fallen before he passed away in Grenoble in 1988.

Laurent

The STO

The Service du travail obligatoire
(English: Compulsory Work Service; STO)
"Because we are convinced
that working is healthy!"

As the exploits on the Eastern Front devoured such enormous masses of soldiers, 300 000 German workers were automatically incorporated into the German army by order of Hitler in 1942. Because this caused a serious labor shortage in Germany, Obergruppenführer Fritz Sauckel was given the task of solving this problem one way or another. The Reich was already commandeering innumerable tons of raw materials from the occupied territories. At that time it also demanded the service of hundreds of thousands, even millions of people, from all over Europe, who were needed to keep the Nazi war machine turning. For France alone, for the duration of the war and excluding the POW's who were toiling already, more than 600 000 people were deported for work. Every single one at the behest of the Vichy government as it could not turn down any requests made by its "beloved" Führer.

Those who were requisitioned for STO had a simple choice: either go to work or alternatively hole up, perhaps even resist by joining the maquis like that of the Vercors for example. Surely, close to two million French citizens of different walks of life were still in Germany at the end of the war.

** The fact that some folks willingly went to Germany has since long been a delicate subject. The Vichy regime had negociated that one POW would be set free in exchange for every three workers who turned up. With this in mind, try to understand that some people took up work for the foe only to obtain the release of a close friend or relative. Then again, others may have had sympathies for the German cause. Thus it became difficult to discern sacrifice from collaboration. That could become a matter of life and death at the end of war when those suspected of collaboration were hunted down and punished. Some things were definitely hard to explain when liberation came...*

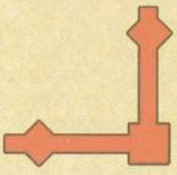
Laurent



TOPOGRAPHY

THE MOUNTAIN...

CONTOUR LINE



A *contour line* is one that separates two areas that are different elevations.
Shots that cross a red line have their range limited to one square beyond the line, unless the shooter or the target is adjacent to the *contour line*.

Effects on *terrain elements* that reduce *line of sight* apply their effects normally.
Infantry units block *line of sight* if both the shooter and the target are infantry units.
Depending on the type of terrain (hill, bridge, beach, etc.), the *contour line* may affect the movement of crossing units.

ELEVATED POSITION



A unit in an *elevated position* can fire at units outside the element as long as its *LoS* does not cross any square of the elevated position or any walls of the *elevated position*.
A unit in an *elevated position* is less hindered by *obstacles* that block or reduce *line of sight*. So when the *LoS* of a unit in an *elevated position* crosses a *terrain element* or a vehicle, the only affected squares are those directly adjacent to the vehicle or terrain.
If the *line of sight* crosses several obstacle squares, count all the modifiers.
But if the target is not directly adjacent to a vehicle, terrain element, or an *obstacle*, then no obstacle penalties are applied and *LoS* is not blocked.
Infantry units never block the *LoS* of a unit in an *elevated position*.
It is always possible to fire on an *elevated position* from another *elevated position*, unless a third one blocks the *line of sight* between them.
A unit that can be targeted by a unit in an *elevated position* can in return target the elevated position or the unit within.
Elevated positions block the *LoS* of units in other *elevated positions*.

SCENARIO 1 – BRIEFING

AMBUSH AT THE CROIX HAUTE PASS

"Fall in men!,"... Captain Pierre Tanant spoke with a clear voice:"The Germans have taken the Northern side of the plateau... But we won't let those Nazis get away with it! We are on our turf here!!! An enemy convoy is heading towards Grenoble. We shall prevent it from reaching its destination as we shall destroy it here, at the Croix Haute pass. Get ready to move out!"
Lieutenant Vernon Hooper, the military advisor commissioned to train the resistants, acquiesced: "The moment we have been waiting for has finally arrived. We shall join you, Captain..."

1- BATTLEFIELD AND DEPLOYMENT





2- COMPOSITION OF THE ARMIES



Core Box, German Army Box, blister pack 1ST SS Panzer Division and Civilians under Fire are necessary to play this scenario.

Use US or Commonwealth order tokens and dice if you do not have the FFI versions.







3- PREPARATION

The FFI player uses the US or Commonwealth card deck.

Remove from this deck:
Don't stop, Hit and Run, It bounced right off it, Precision, Ram, Repairs, Resupply, Speed set up, Surprise as well as all **Artillery** and **Aviation** cards.
Remove from German deck:
Bogged down, Booby trapped, Precision, Ram, Repairs, Return to sender, Speed set up, Surprise, Weak Point as well as all **Artillery** and **Aviation** cards.

The FFI player may deploy anywhere on the map.

The German player has the initiative. Position the corresponding marker on Turn **1**.

Each player draws **4** cards.

4- PARTICULAR INFORMATION

This game is played in **6** turns.

The German troops enter in Turn **1** through the squares with red arrows. Units either move with an Order in the Activation phase or without during the Supply phase.

The German player must succeed in getting at least **3** vehicles off the map through the exit squares denoted by blue arrows before the end of Turn **6**.

5- VICTORY CONDITIONS

GERMAN VICTORY: The Germans win if they succeed in getting at least **3** vehicles off the map, through the exit squares denoted by blue arrows, before the end of Turn **6**.

FFI VICTORY: The FFI win if the Germans fail to get at least **3** vehicles safely off the map before the end of Turn **6**.

SCENARIO 2 – BRIEFING

VALCHEVRIERE

"Oberst Schwehr, we have been informed about a Resistance rear support base at Valchevrière. The enemy could launch an offensive from that location or even attack us from behind. Your troops have been selected because of the topography of the region. You are free to do whatever it takes in order to obliterate this menace!"

1- BATTLEFIELD AND DEPLOYMENT





2- COMPOSITION OF THE ARMIES





Core Box, FFI punchboard or Civilians under fire are necessary to play this scenario.

Use US or Commonwealth order tokens, dice and grenades if you do not have the FFI versions.

3- PREPARATION



The FFI player uses the US or Commonwealth card deck.



Remove Return to sender from this deck.
Remove from both decks:
Bogged down, Don't stop, Hit and Run, It bounced right off it, Precision, Ram, Repairs, Speed set up, Weak Point as well as all **Artillery** and **Aviation** cards.

The FFI player deploys anywhere on the map except in the red zone.

The German player has initiative.
Position the corresponding marker on Turn **1**.

Each player draws **4** cards.

4- PARTICULAR INFORMATION

This game is played in **6** turns.

The German troops enter in Turn **1** through the squares denoted by red arrows. Units either move with an Order in the Activation phase or without during the Supply phase.

Eliminated German units may reappear through the squares denoted by red arrows.

Starting at Turn **3** and during later turns they may also return through the squares with blue arrows. Units either move with an Order in their next Activation phase or without during their next Supply phase.

The German player must be in control of at least **1** of **2** objectives at the end of Turn **6**.

A player controls an objective if only friendly units and no enemy troops are adjacent to it.

5- VICTORY CONDITIONS

FFI VICTORY: The FFI win if the Germans control neither of the 2 objectives at the end of Turn **6**.

GERMAN VICTORY: The Germans win if they control at least **1** objective at the end of Turn **6**.



SCENARIO 3 – BRIEFING

THE BLACK WINGS

"Ever more enemy units are converging on the region. After the bombardment, glider planes have flown in to drop off Nazi troops on the plateau. Most likely the first German paratroopers entered Vassieux. We must regain control of that town, at least to buy enough time to evacuate the civilians who are present there. In short order, when our men are ready, we shall launch an offensive. Let's hope no more German reinforcements are due any time soon."

1- BATTLEFIELD AND DEPLOYMENT



TERRAIN TILES: C1-A / C2-A - CA1-A / CA3-A



2- COMPOSITION OF THE ARMIES

FFI



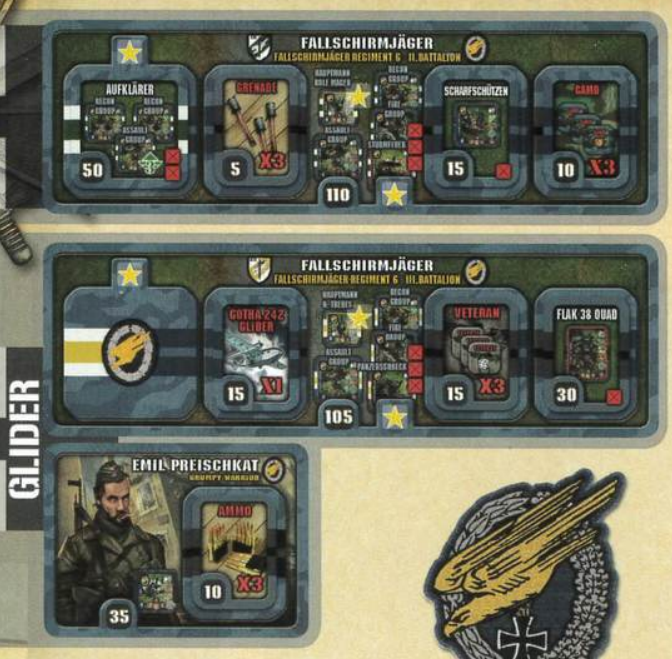
CIVILIANS





Core Box, Civilians under fire and Carentan expansion are necessary to play this scenario.

Use US or Commonwealth order tokens and dice if you do not have the FFI versions.





3- PREPARATION



Remove from US deck: Bogged down, Precision, Ram, Repairs, Resupply, Speed set up, Weak Point as well as all **Artillery** and **Aviation** cards.



Remove from German deck: Don't stop, Hit and Run, It bounced right off it, Precision, Ram, Repairs, Return to sender, Speed set up as well as all **Artillery** and **Aviation** cards.

The FFI player deploys the civilians first in the red zone.
The German player then deploys in the same zone.



The FFI player has initiative.
Position the corresponding marker on Turn **1**.

Each player draws **4** cards.

4- PARTICULAR INFORMATION

This game is played in **8** turns.

Even though civilians can usually stack together in one square, they are not allowed to do so in this scenario.



The FFI troops enter no sooner than Turn **2** through the squares denoted by blue arrows. Units either move with an Order in the Activation phase or without during the Supply phase.



The German glider enters the game in Turn **4**. It is positioned on a square next to and facing one of the red arrows where it will unload the Paratroops and the Flak Quad.

The goal for both players is to score the most Victory Points by destroying enemy units. Alternatively VP can be gained or lost as follows:

- Any time either player eliminates a Civilian unit with combat values X/X/X they lose **1** point as a penalty. This is not the case for the Civilian unit with the "Objective" trait.
- The German player receives **5** points for liquidating the Civilian unit with the "Objective" trait, however, these **5** points go to the French player instead if the unit survives the battle.
- The German player scores **1** point for dispatching any Civilian unit with combat values other than X/X/X.
- The player who controls the large building in the lower right corner of tile CA3-A at the end of Turn **6**, scores **10** points.
- The player who controls any other building at the end of Turn **6**, scores **5** points. No points are awarded for controlling the Ruins.

A player is in control of a building when only friendly troops and no enemies are inside.

5- VICTORY CONDITIONS



The player with the most Victory Points at the end of Turn **8** wins the game.



CLASSIFIED

SPECIAL RULES

Climber



This unit can move into squares that have the Wall symbol.





These squares are considered *Difficult Passages* for it, so the unit must stop each time it enters a square.

If you use the Surprise card or use the Urban Fighter ability, the unit can move into an elevated position through a window.

Glider

Restricted to Infantry, vehicles that occupy a single square



This option gives you **1** or **2** Glider markers.
Each glider has a carrying capacity.
A **1**-square vehicle uses up all the carrying capacity.



Vehicles that occupy two squares cannot be transported aboard gliders.
During deployment, you may position your Glider markers anywhere around the board, putting them next to a square that your transported units can enter.

Put the units the glider has on board on the glider marker (without exceeding its carrying capacity).
If the glider is a piece of gear provided by a *recruitment tile*, the units must belong to the *recruitment tile* or to the *recruitment tile* options to which the Glider option belongs.

Carried units will be able to enter the battlefield through the square the arrow points at, if they are given an Order token or during a Supply Phase.
Units in the glider may not fire until they come into play.



The Order(s) special ability of officers applies, even if they are still in the glider.
If the glider's exit square is occupied by an enemy unit and no unit already in play can clear the square, you can:
- either give an Order token to one of the units inside the glider and make an assault. If the assault fails, the attacking unit falls back into the glider (if it survived);
- or move out with a vehicle and stay in the exit square to drive out the enemy unit.

If no unit can assault or there isn't a vehicle in the glider, units in the glider are stuck inside as long as the exit square is occupied.